



SHAILESH RAVAL

Discovery of Roots

AHMEDABAD For astronaut Sunita Williams, it was a true homecoming when she visited her father's home state for the third time. The 42-year-old, who spent a record 195 days aboard NASA's space shuttle Discovery, was accompanied by her 70-year-old neurologist father, Dipak Pandya.

Feet firmly on terra firma this time round, Williams first visited her ancestral village Jhulasan in north Gujarat. Her father studied in Ahmedabad and Surat before

migrating to the US in 1958 and marrying Bonnie, Sunita's American mother of Slovenian origin. As Vaishali Sisodiya, a school student put it, "Sunita came, conquered and etched her memory in our hearts for ever."

Williams was felicitated with the Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel Vishwa Pratiba Award for her unique achievement in space travel, by the Vishwa Gujarati Samaj. "I am a bit old now as an astronaut. Here I see

COMING HOME: Williams many future astronauts," said Williams at Sabar-mati Ashram during a visit to a school. "Planet earth looks beautiful from space. There are no borders on the earth." The Gandhi Ashram was packed with children thronging to see Williams as her sister Falguni translated her speech into Gujarati. She revealed that her father had been an RSS worker in the US for many years.

The trip also gave Williams an opportunity to pay homage to her slain cousin and former Gujarat home minister Haren Pandya who was shot dead in 2003. The astronaut had started her career as a helicopter pilot. As she left Gujarat, the words of Chief Minister Narendra Modi expressed while felicitating her must have rung in her ears, "On being honoured in his native Coorg, General Cariappa said there is nothing that can match the pleasure that you get when you are felicitated in your homeland."

by Uday Mahurkar

SIGNPOSTS

SENTENCED: Dara Singh to life imprisonment for killing a Catholic priest in September 1999. He is already serving life imprisonment for killing Australian missionary Graham Stuart Staines and his two minor sons in January 1999.



DIED: Senior BJP leader and former Union law minister **Jana Krishnamurthy**,

79. He was the BJP national president from 2001-02 and was a founder national secretary of BJP.

ARRESTED: Former Uttar Pradesh chief secretary and 1967-batch IAS official **Akhand Pratap Singh**, for allegedly amassing wealth through corrupt means.

CONFERRED: On BJP leader **Sushma Swaraj**, the award for Outstanding Parliamentarian, 2004, by President Pratibha Patil. Swaraj is the first woman MP to be presented with the award.

VIS-A-VIS **RAM VILAS VEDANTI** former BJP MP **versus** **ARCOT N. VEERASAMY** DMK leader

“
Anyone who
cuts off
Karunanidhi's
head will
be weighed
against
gold.”



SAURABH SINGH

“
The reckless north
Indian should
apologise, or we'll
ensure that no one
from the **BJP** will be
allowed to roam the
streets of Tamil Nadu.”

EPILOGUE: Though a warrior, even Lord Ram would have squirmed at this violent display of passion.